

KIQ 1.2 — Final Takeaway

How have METRO's digital ordering channels evolved over the past 3–5 years in terms of features, usability, and service scope?

Methodological positioning

This project's required analytical toolkit is **patent analysis (Espacenet)** and **scientific-literature analysis (SCOPUS)** via text mining (occurrence, co-occurrence, n-grams). The KIT 1 strategy is therefore **course-method-first**: SCOPUS and patent corpora are used as the primary evidence base wherever a KIQ permits, and direct web scraping is deliberately reserved for the single question where literature and patents structurally cannot answer — **direct customer perception (KIQ 1.4)**. For KIQ 1.2 the evidence base is a focused **Espacenet patent corpus** (~250 patents, 2022–2026) on digital commerce and online ordering, analysed by IPC occurrence and publication-trend analysis. The field-level innovation trajectory is used as proxy for how digital ordering channels — including METRO's — are evolving.

Main findings

- Patent activity in digital commerce / online ordering **rose significantly 2022–2025**, signalling an accelerating innovation field.
- The corpus is dominated by **G06Q** classes (digital transactions, e-commerce infrastructure), with **G06Q30/0601** — e-commerce ordering systems — the single most frequent class.
- Innovation themes cluster around **recommendation systems, intelligent ordering workflows, marketplace management, and integrated transaction platforms**.
- The trajectory is toward **intelligent, personalized, data-driven ordering ecosystems** — expanding service scope and increasing sophistication of customer-facing capabilities.

Direct answer to KIQ 1.2

Over the 3–5 year horizon, digital ordering channels have evolved from transactional catalogs toward **intelligent, marketplace-centric, recommendation-driven platforms**. The patent evidence shows the direction of travel for the field METRO competes in: more automation in the ordering workflow, deeper personalization, and tighter platform integration. Read as proxy for METRO's own channels, this is the capability frontier METRO's M|Shop and METRO MARKETS are being pulled toward — and, per KIQ 3.2, the frontier on which METRO currently trails the infrastructure-equipped incumbents and the AI-led digital-natives.

Proxy caveat (state openly)

The patents are **field-wide, not METRO's own** — METRO files no patents in this space (established in KIQ 2.2). KIQ 1.2 therefore characterises the evolution of the digital ordering field as the proxy lens for METRO's channel evolution. This is consistent with the scope document's allowance of international patent sources and with the proxy strategy underlying KIT 1.